

Tertullian 203

De praescriptione haereticorum, c. 20 — all the churches one and apostolic; the communion of peace (CSEL 70, pp. 23–24)

20. Christ Jesus our Lord — let him permit me to say it for the moment — whoever he is, of whatever God the Son, of whatever substance man and God, teacher of whatever faith, promiser of whatever reward: what he was, what he had been, what will of the Father he was administering, what he laid down that a man must do — this, so long as he was acting on earth, he himself proclaimed, whether openly to the people or apart to his disciples, from among whom he had chosen twelve foremost ones to his own side, destined to be teachers to the nations. And so, when one of them had been struck off, he ordered the remaining eleven, as he departed to the Father after the resurrection, to go and teach the nations, who were to be baptized into the Father and the Son and the Holy Spirit. Immediately, then, the apostles — a term which means “those sent” — having taken by lot a twelfth, Matthias, into the place of Judas, on the authority of the prophecy which is [[p. 24]] in the psalm of David, and having obtained the promised power of the Holy Spirit for mighty works and for utterance, first throughout Judaea bore witness to their faith in Jesus Christ and founded churches; then, setting out into the world, they published to the nations the same doctrine of the same faith, and likewise founded churches in each and every city. From these the remaining churches thereafter borrowed the shoot of the faith and the seeds of doctrine — and daily borrow them — that they may become churches; and by this very fact they too will be reckoned apostolic, as the offspring of the apostolic churches. Every kind must needs be reckoned by its own origin. And so, for all that the churches are so many and so great, there is but that one, the first, from the apostles, from which all others are. Thus all are first, and all apostolic, so long as all are one. The communion of peace, and the title of brotherhood, and the mutual token of hospitality prove their unity — rights which no other principle governs than the one tradition of the same sacrament (*sacramentum*).

De praescriptione haereticorum, c. 21 — the prescription rule (pp. 24–25)

21. From this point, therefore, we frame our prescription (*praescriptio*): if the Lord Christ Jesus sent the apostles to preach, no others are to be received as preachers than those whom Christ appointed — since [[p. 25]] no one knows the Father but the Son and he to whom the Son has revealed him, and the Son does not appear to have revealed him to any others than the apostles whom he sent to preach — namely, that which he had revealed to them. But what they preached — that is, what Christ revealed to them — here too I shall lay down by prescription that it ought to be

proved in no other way than through those same churches which the apostles themselves founded, by preaching to them both by the living voice, as they say, and afterwards by their letters. If these things are so, it is accordingly established that every doctrine which agrees with those apostolic churches, the wombs and originals of the faith, is to be reckoned as truth — holding without doubt that which the churches received from the apostles, the apostles from Christ, Christ from God; but that every doctrine is to be prejudged as of falsehood which savours of anything contrary to the truth of the churches and of the apostles and of Christ and of God.

De praescriptione haereticorum, c. 28 — the unanimity argument (pp. 34–35)

28. Come now, grant that all have erred; that the apostle too was deceived in bearing his testimony to certain persons; that the Holy Spirit had regard for none of them, so as to lead the church into truth — the Spirit sent by Christ for this very purpose, asked of the Father for this very purpose, that he might be the teacher of truth; grant that he neglected his office — that steward of God, that vicar of Christ — as they allege, suffering the churches meanwhile to understand otherwise, to believe otherwise than he himself was preaching through the apostles: is it likely that so many and so great churches should have gone astray into one and the same faith? Among many outcomes this one result never is: the error would have had to make the doctrine of the churches vary. But what is found one and the same among many is not error, but tradition. [[p. 35]] Let anyone, then, dare to say that they who handed it down were in error.

De praescriptione haereticorum, c. 32 — let them produce the origins of their churches (pp. 39–41)

32. But if any [churches] dare to thrust themselves into the apostolic age, so as to seem to have been handed down by the apostles because they existed under the apostles, we can say: let them then produce the origins of their churches, let them unroll the order of their bishops, running down by succession from the beginning in such a way that that first [[p. 40]] bishop had for his author and predecessor one of the apostles or of the apostolic men — one who nonetheless persevered with the apostles. For it is in this way that the apostolic churches render up their registers: as the church of the Smyrnaeans records that Polycarp was installed by John, as that of the Romans records that Clement was ordained by Peter. In just the same way the rest too present those whom, appointed to the episcopate by the apostles, they possess as transmitters of the apostolic seed. Let the heretics contrive something of the sort. For after their blasphemy, what is unlawful for them? But even if they should contrive it, they will gain nothing; for their very doctrine, when compared with the apostolic, will by its own diversity and contrariety declare that it has for its author neither any apostle nor an apostolic man — because, just as the apostles would not have taught things at variance among themselves, so too the apostolic men would not have put forth things contrary to the apostles, unless indeed those who learned from the apostles preached otherwise. To this standard, therefore, they will be summoned by those churches which, although they can produce no apostle or apostolic man as their own author, being much later — new ones are in fact established every day — nevertheless, agreeing in the same faith, are reckoned no less apostolic for the kinship of their doctrine. And so, when all the heresies are challenged by our churches to [[p. 41]]

both these standards, let them prove themselves apostolic in whatever way they suppose they are. But so far are they from it that they neither are, nor can they prove themselves to be, what they are not; nor are they received into peace and communion by the churches that are in any way apostolic — being, precisely because of the difference of their sacrament (*sacramentum*), in no way apostolic.

De praescriptione haereticorum, c. 36 — the tour of the apostolic sees (pp. 45–47)

36. Come now, you who are willing to exercise your curiosity to better purpose in the business of your salvation: run through the apostolic churches, in which the very chairs of the apostles still preside in their own places, in which their own authentic letters are read aloud, sounding forth the voice and re-presenting the face of each. Is Achaia nearest you? You have Corinth. If you are not far from Macedonia, you have Philippi, you have the Thessalonians. If you can travel into Asia, you have Ephesus. But if you border on Italy, you have Rome, whence authority is at hand for us too. How happy is that church, into which the apostles poured out their whole doctrine along with their blood; where [[p. 46]] Peter is made equal to the Lord's Passion, where Paul is crowned with an end like John's, where the apostle John, after being plunged into burning oil and suffering nothing, is banished to an island! Let us see what she has learned, what she has taught. Together with the African churches too, with whom she shares the token, she knows one God, the Lord, the Creator of the universe, and Christ Jesus, of the Virgin Mary the Son of God the Creator and the raiser-up of the flesh; she blends the Law and the Prophets with the writings of the evangelists and apostles; from these she drinks her faith; this faith she seals with water, clothes with the Holy Spirit, feeds with the Eucharist, exhorts to martyrdom — and against this instruction she receives no one. This is the instruction — I no longer say, the one which foretold the coming heresies, but the one from which the heresies came forth. Yet they are not from it, since they came to be against it. Even from the kernel of the olive, mild and rich, there necessarily springs the rough wild-olive; even from the seed of the fig, most pleasing and sweet, there rises the windy and empty wild-fig. So too [[p. 47]] the heresies are from our shrub, though not of our stock — from the grain of truth, but, through falsehood, gone wild.

Appendix: De monogamia, c. 2 — the Montanist Tertullian claims the Paraclete (CSEL 76, pp. 45–46)

2, 1. And so they reproach the discipline of monogamy as a heresy, and for no cause more than this are they driven to deny the Paraclete: because they judge him the instituter of a new discipline — and, in their eyes, a most harsh one. Hence on this point first a stand must be made, in a general review: whether it can be that the Paraclete taught anything of such a kind as could be reckoned either new, against the catholic tradition, or burdensome, against the light burden [cf. Mt 11:30]. 2. But on both counts the Lord himself has pronounced. For in saying, “I have yet many things to speak to you, but you cannot bear them now; when the Holy Spirit comes, he will lead you into all truth,” he sufficiently sets forth that the Spirit will teach things which may be reckoned both new, as never before published, and somewhat burdensome, as for that reason not published. 3. “Therefore,” you say, “by this argument anything whatever, new and burdensome, will be able to be ascribed to the Paraclete, even if it should have come from the adversary spirit.” Not so; for the adversary spirit would betray itself by the diversity of its

preaching, first adulter-[[p. 46]]ating the rule of faith and so adulterating the order of discipline — because the corruption of that whose rank is prior comes first, that is, of faith, which is prior to discipline: one must be a heretic concerning God first, and then concerning [moral] institution. 4. But the Paraclete, having many things to teach which the Lord deferred to him, will according to that predefinition first bear witness to Christ himself — such as we believe him, with the whole order of God the Creator — and will glorify him and make mention of him; and thus, out of that principal rule, he will reveal those many matters that belong to the disciplines, the integrity of the preaching speaking on their behalf: [matters] though new, since they are now being revealed, though burdensome, since not even now are they borne, yet belonging to no other Christ than the one who declared that he had also many other things which were to be taught by the Paraclete — no less burdensome to these [of today] than to those [of the apostles' day] by whom they were not yet then borne.